

Looking Back to Look Forward: Keeping SIGGRAPH Vibrant for Another 50 Years

SIGGRAPH 2023 Retrospective Panel

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ABSTRACT

Panelists will discuss the effects of rapid technological change, global economic shifts, and conference site characteristics on the SIGGRAPH conference during its first 50 occurrences.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Conference growth;**

KEYWORDS

ACM SIGGRAPH Conference, Running a conference

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1 INTRODUCTION

During its 50-year history, the ACM SIGGRAPH conference has experienced both rapid growth and gradual contraction. The conference has routinely achieved excellence across all programs and all phases.

This panel features conference chairs and leaders who have succeeded during times of scaling up and scaling down. They have all delivered excellent content and attendee experience while managing risks, challenges, and opportunities.

Panelists will discuss the effects of rapid technological change, global economic shifts, and conference site characteristics. They will share first-hand experiences and lessons learned. They will also look forward and propose strategies to keep SIGGRAPH as vibrant as it has been over its first 50 occurrences.

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Bring your questions! We're setting aside 30 minutes with some of the people who have made the SIGGRAPH conference such a success.

2 BACKGROUND

Many conflate the SIGGRAPH conference with the SIGGRAPH organization. While the organization and the conference depend on one another, they are managed differently. The organization has an elected board of officers who serve multi-year terms and focus on a broad range of activities, including conference site selection, history, and education. This panel focuses on how SIGGRAPH has managed to succeed in spite of (and maybe because of) all the challenges.

Volunteers did everything until 1980 when professionals were contracted to manage the exhibits and handle registration. Co-chairs ran the conference until 1997 when a single chair supported by a chief staff executive model arrived. The formal position of chief staff executive disappeared in 2015. Further complications arose when conference delivery had to evolve from 'everyone on-site' to 'all virtual' to 'on-site plus virtual (aka hybrid)' over the past 3 years.

Modern conferences are led by a volunteer chair supported by a paid team of professionals. The professionals handle the detail needed to make the conference run properly (e.g., registration, exhibits, on-site services, A/V). The volunteer chair, who has a wide degree of latitude, is the person in charge and focuses on a single year's event.

This panel will focus on how the conference itself has succeeded and evolved since SIGGRAPH74 debuted in Boulder CO. Just about everything has needed to change since the initial, collegial gathering of 600. The conference had to evolve to foster new technology, technologies that spun out and created their own conferences, growth and decline in the number of attendees, changes in attendee demographics, and even a pandemic. Consider the problems of moving from computer-aided design and education to flying logos and eye candy to full-length films; from mainframes to workstations to personal computers to the cloud and parallel GPU processing; from 600 attendees to 45,000+ to the current level of 10,000 – 15,000 to name just a few. The panelists will discuss the good, the bad, and the ugly that challenged them.

3 THE PANEL

Panel leader **Dave Kasik** retired as Boeing's Senior Technical Fellow in visualization and interactive techniques. His work with CAD and geometry visualization have been part of Boeing's production systems since the mid-1980's. He pioneered the use of visual analytics to help extract more information from complex non-geometric data.

Dave earned an MS in Computer Science from University of Colorado in 1972 and a BA in Quantitative Studies from Johns Hopkins in 1970. He's an ACM Fellow. ACM SIGGRAPH involvement includes papers, panels, courses, the Pioneers, exhibits, and history. Dave has attended all North American SIGGRAPH conferences since 1974.

Terrence Masson has 30 years of computer graphics production and education leadership experience. As an animation and visual effects artist and producer, he developed live action and animated films, VR/AR, and games.

His CG101: A Computer Graphics Industry Reference is a standard text worldwide.

Terrence worked on 20+ feature films, including Hook and three Star Wars episodes. He supervised interactive projects (e.g., SimCity4) and developed the original CG animation method for South Park in 1996.

An active volunteer with SIGGRAPH since 1988, Terrence served as 2006 Computer Animation Festival Chair, 2010 Conference Chair, and Outstanding Service Awards Chair.

Munkhtsetseg Nandigjav (Muunuu) completed her B.S. in computer graphics technology at Purdue University and M.F.A. in animation at SCAD. Muunuu worked with organizations and clients, including DreamWorks Animation, General Electric Aviation, NASA, Samtec, MakeLab, BMW, Brown Forman, and more with her background in design and 3D production. For over a decade, Muunuu has been part of ACM SIGGRAPH. She recently was responsible for leading the SIGGRAPH 2022 as the conference chair in Vancouver, Canada. At SCAD, Muunuu has been serving as a professor and chair of Digital Communication.

Adele Newton has developed and managed a range of programs and strategic international partnerships in the university, technology and not-for-profit sectors across Canada, within North America and in Africa, Europe and China.

Adele has served in a range of SIGGRAPH roles, including Registration Chair in 1984, Conference Co-Chair for SIGGRAPH 88, chair of the Site Selection Committee, member of the Executive Committee as Chair of the Conference Planning Committee and chair of the SIGGRAPH 2019 Business Symposium. She is currently Chair of the SIGGRAPH Communications Committee.

Adele is a graduate of the Faculty of Mathematics at the University of Waterloo.

Scott Owen had a fourteen-year academic career in Chemistry and then moved to the new Georgia State University Computer Science Department, where he is currently a Professor Emeritus of Computer Science. His research interests are in Computer Graphics, Computer Graphics Education, and Computer Graphics in Education. His service as an ACM SIGGRAPH volunteer includes Chair and Director of the Education Committee, SIGGRAPH97 Conference Chair, CAG Chair, President, Past President, and Chair of the

Nominations Committee. He is currently Chair of the Governance Advisory Board and the Outstanding Service Award Committee. He received the SIGGRAPH Outstanding Service Award in 2018.

Mikki Rose is a Character Simulation, Technical Animation, and Groom Supervisor at Mikros Animation Studios. She earned BS degrees in Computer Science and Mass Communication from Middle Tennessee State and an MFA in Digital Production Arts from Clemson. Former studio credits include Rhythm & Hues, Sony Pictures Imageworks, Blue Sky Studios, and Walt Disney Animation Studios. Mikki started as a Student Volunteer at SIGGRAPH 2002. She has gone on to lead multiple conference programs and the 2019 conference. She is now Conference Advisory Group Chair and a member of the Executive Committee, as well as an active NYC ACM SIGGRAPH chapter member.

4 QUESTIONS FOR THE PANEL

- What was the most difficult aspect of running your conference?
- During your conference's decade, what technologies became prominent? Left SIGGRAPH? Withered and died?
- Describe the aspect(s) that surprised you most.
- How do you see the SIGGRAPH organization and conference evolving?
- What actions can SIGGRAPH take to sustain excellence?